Strategic Obfuscation, Alternative Information and Electoral Accountability

Comments

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The (very) short version

As an elected official…

I want to hurting my odds of (re)election with a stochastic poor signal, *if I’m ahead*.

I can use *obfuscation* to make the signal noisier and thus less effective.

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Figure 1: Up 2:0 at half…

Obfuscating…

- is **more useful** when voters have an **indirect public signal about me**.
- is **less useful** when voters have an **direct public signal about me**.
- With an illustration of how this may affect presidential-mayoral elections.)

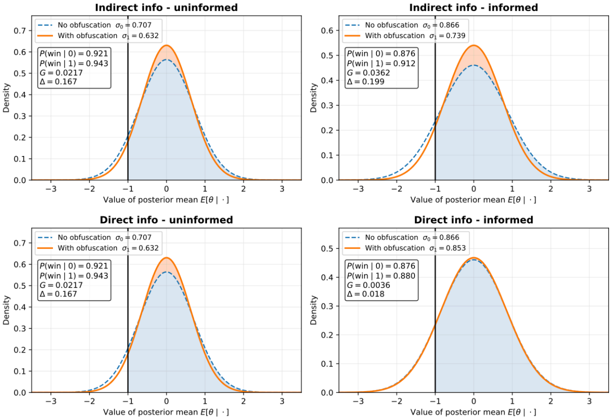

Figure 1: **Posterior-mean distributions with and without obfuscation.** Each panel

Figure 2: Figure 1

"*It is very preliminary, as you will see*"

- Wish my papers look like this when I call them "preliminary"…
- Obviously timely topic
- Very clean model with non-intuitive results (variance of signal versus variance of type)

Theory: information

The incumbent chooses whether to deploy the obfuscation device, $x \in \{0, 1\}$*. Then,* g_x*,* s^θ*,* s^ν *and their components (including* θ*) are realised. Representative voters in each district observe both the realised outcome* g_x *and the incumbent's choice* x*.*

- Be an incumbent, know b, yet not to know your own type?
- Critical to prevent inference from obfuscation action x: *Because* x *is set before the realisation of* θ*, it has no signalling role in equilibrium.*
- (Side not: if b was unknown to voter, then x would reveal it, no?)
- Maybe: draw θ prior to x, but make x unobservable?

Theory: obfuscation

- Obfuscation ($x \in \{0, 1\}$): *From transfers with uncertain implementation and administrative complexity to message flooding and low-quality propaganda*
  - Vague
  - Dichotomous, costless
- Obfuscation output+tech has changed (social media, etc.)
  - Suggests that it has a *cost* and *intensity*
  - But then: what about cost sensitivity or budget constraints?
  - (Could also be helpful empirically: eg volume of press releases, etc.)
- Effectiveness of x:
  - Affected by env factors (media, literacy)?
  - Maybe easier: explore comparative stats of σ_s^2 (var of private signal)

Results

- Most results/comparative statics on $b > 0$ ($\sim$ incumbency advantage)
- Literature on incumbency disadvantage ($b < 0$) (Uppal 2009; Klasnja 2015; Ariga 2015)
- Allows for cross-national comparisons over the range of b
- Allows to think about the link between institutional setting and obfuscation

Minor comments

- Model challenger (battles of muddling vs tightening signals)
- Apply to communication incentives during campaigns (dynamic): content vs obfuscation
- $\rightarrow$ current model cannot explain over-time variation beyond shocks to b, but obfuscation seems to vary
- Model bureaucracies as source of info
- Optimal media allocation?
- Organization and management
  - Relations between regulated firm and regulator
  - Relations between CEO and board (NB: less compelling)
- Lemma 5: typo? Δ^{NI} instead of Δ^{UI}?

Thank you!

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References I

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Uppal, Yogesh. 2009. "The Disadvantaged Incumbents: Estimating Incumbency Effects in Indian State Legislatures." *Public Choice* 138 (1): 9–27.